polymath and a lifelong politician who had served as external affairs minister under Indira and Rajiv. He knew foreign service officers well and they expected him to give greater say to the professionals in the ministry and in diplomatic missions abroad. Instead, Rao continued to concentrate decision making in the prime minister's office.

Another prime minister with prior experience as foreign minister under his belt was Inder Kumar Gujral, who was passionate about foreign policy like Nehru and retained the post of foreign minister during his short tenure as prime minister. Gujral came to power intent on leaving a legacy in foreign policy especially with respect to India's immediate neighbourhood, South Asia – the Gujral doctrine. Without weakening the PMO, Gujral distinguished himself from his predecessors by relying heavily on outside experts and academics. This led to frequent clashes between the prime minister and the permanent foreign service.[23]

The BJP's Atal Bihari Vajpayee restored a semblance of consultation in the making foreign policy. He had served as external affairs minister during the Janata Party government (1977–79) and, after short stints as prime minister in 1996 and 1998, presided over a full five-year term as prime minister beginning in 1999. As a consummate politician, Vajpayee knew almost all opposition leaders and was able to reach out to them to build consensus on external relations. On certain issues he consulted his cabinet, his party and other members of the coalition government and even members of the opposition Congress party. One such issue was US president George W. Bush's request in 2003–04 for Indian troops for the war in Iraq. The decision to not get militarily involved in Iraq reflected a wide consensus. On other issues, for example his decision to extend a hand of friendship to Pakistan while giving a speech in Kashmir, Vajpayee acted alone and without too much consultation.

Under Vajpayee, a major institutional change occurred when the BJP-led government created the National Security Council (NSC) Secretariat